The Jade Cauldron

Book I: Of Common Tonics, Uncommon Elixirs, and the Proper Use of an Hourglass

Compiled by Scholar-Physician Wei Zhen of the Academy of Apothecaries

A field copy prepared for physicians, travelers, and curious householders of Tianxia

Preface: On the Virtues of a Modest Cauldron

A physician may possess twelve bronze vessels, a cabinet of exotic roots, and an apprentice capable of reciting the names of ten thousand herbs, yet still fail to prepare a useful medicine. A traveler with a clean pot, a little water, and the correct plant may succeed where the physician has failed. Thus I have reduced my recipes to their essentials: one fluid to carry the virtue, and no more than three substances to give it purpose.

Readers familiar with the elaborate extractive systems of other academies will find no requirement here for separate salts, ashes, essences, sublimates, or suspensions. Grind what must be ground; burn what must be burned; distill when a vapor must be caught. A preparation becomes a potion when the ingredients are made to act together, not when the apothecary invents a longer name for it.

The formulae below are fictional alchemy for use in Tianxia. Although some names are familiar from other alchemical catalogues, their combinations, effects, times, and prices have been adapted for tabletop play. These are not instructions for real consumption. Many named plants and substances would be unsafe outside fiction.

Chapter I: The Rule of One Vessel

Every recipe has exactly one solvent and between one and three distinct solutes. The solvent is the fluid carrier: water, oil, wine, vinegar, tree sap, rice wash, broth, or another obtainable liquid. Solutes are the active materials: leaves, roots, powders, mineral dust, monster parts, or burned ash. An ingredient may be crushed, dissolved, or suspended; it need not disappear completely.

Grade	Solutes	Typical time	Suggested cost / rarity
Common	1	1 turn of the hourglass (10 min)	5–25 gp; common herbs
Skilled	2	2 turns (20 min)	25–100 gp; mixed or rare materials

Grade	Solutes	Typical time	Suggested cost / rarity
Masterwork	3	3 turns (30 min)	100+ gp; exotic or perilous materials

One batch fills one standard potion vial and produces one consumable. One listed portion of each solute is needed. A solvent consumes one small flask or cup; unless unusually rare, its cost is included. Amounts are deliberately descriptive rather than measured by weight.

At the table: If the ingredients and equipment are available, brewing takes the listed time without a roll. Under threat, with improvised equipment, or when substitutions are attempted, the GM may ask for an Intelligence check with alchemist's supplies or herbalism kit: DC 10 (Common), DC 13 (Skilled), DC 16 (Masterwork). On failure, ingredients are spent and the brew is inert. A result 5 or more below the DC gives the GM permission to introduce a harmless but inconvenient complication.

Chapter II: Implements and the Six Operations

Operation	At the brewing table
Grinding	Crush a dried leaf, shell, or root with mortar and pestle to free its virtue.
Mixing	Fold the prepared solutes into the selected solvent, stirring steadily.
Boiling	Heat a vessel until a quiet simmer carries flavor, color, or magic into the fluid.
Burning	Reduce a prepared material to ash, then add the cool ash as a suspended solute.
Dissolving	Stir a powder or soft resin until dispersed; sediment is acceptable if shaken before use.
Distillation	Heat the mixture and lead its vapor through a cool tube into a receiving vial.

An **hourglass** measures one turn as ten minutes. Turn it once for common draughts, twice for skilled preparations, and three times for masterwork batches. A sandglass is a convenient clock, not a magical necessity. Boiling, grinding, and distillation are descriptions of fantasy crafting, not precise laboratory procedures.

Chapter III: Common Remedies and Roadside Draughts

Entry I — Potion of Healing

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Rogue’s Morsel

Preparation: Grind the herb to a red-green paste; dissolve it in warm water and strain through linen for one turn.

Game effect: Restore 2d4 + 2 hit points when drunk.

Apothecary’s observation: *Fresh specimens stain the pestle; dried ones are less fragrant but equally useful.*

Entry II — Antidote

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Clean water

Solutes: Mugwort

Preparation: Grind the leaves finely, boil for one turn, and decant the clear green liquid.

Game effect: End the poisoned condition caused by a mundane poison; against a magical poison, gain an immediate new saving throw.

Apothecary’s observation: *This antidote does not mend damage already dealt by poison.*

Entry III — Draught of Animal Speech

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Acorn Truffle

Preparation: Slice the truffle, grind it, and mix into the wine. Let it settle for one turn.

Game effect: For 1 hour, you can understand and verbally communicate with beasts as under *speak with animals*.

Apothecary’s observation: *Do not expect a donkey to become clever merely because you can understand its complaints.*

Entry IV — Feather-Fall Cordial

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Autumn Crocus

Preparation: Grind the petals, steep for one turn, and catch the pale liquid before it darkens.

Game effect: For 1 hour, when you fall, you can use your reaction to gain the effect of *feather fall* on yourself. The effect then ends.

Apothecary's observation: *A poor remedy for a fall already completed.*

Entry V — Glorious Vaulting Tonic

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Tree sap

Solutes: Wispweed

Preparation: Warm the sap and dissolve crushed Wispweed into it for one turn.

Game effect: For 10 minutes, your jump distance is tripled, as with *jump*.

Apothecary's observation: *A leap made without considering where one lands remains a foolish leap.*

Entry VI — Clear-Eye Tea

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Hot water

Solutes: Chrysanthemum blossoms

Preparation: Steep the blossoms for one turn; stir and strain before sealing.

Game effect: For 1 hour, gain advantage on one Wisdom (Perception) check relying on sight; the potion is expended when used.

Apothecary's observation: *A popular examination-day tea, though no decoction can replace study.*

Entry VII — Ginger-Warmth Draught

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Rice wash

Solutes: Ginger root

Preparation: Crush the root and simmer in rice wash for one turn.

Game effect: For 1 hour, ignore the first level of exhaustion imposed solely by ordinary cold exposure (it is suppressed, not removed).

Apothecary's observation: *Common among ferrymen who work before sunrise.*

Entry VIII — Bitter-Reed Stomach Tonic

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Common | **Hourglass:** 1 turn

Solvent: Boiled water

Solutes: Lotus seed

Preparation: Grind the dry seed and boil for one turn, then stir the settled powder back in.

Game effect: For 1 hour, gain advantage on saving throws against becoming sickened by spoiled food or mundane foul smells; no effect on magical poison.

Apothecary's observation: *A traveler should still avoid the suspicious stew.*

Chapter IV: Skilled Draughts for the Practiced Hand

Entry IX — Potion of Greater Healing

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Balsam, Rogue's Morsel

Preparation: Burn a pinch of dried Balsam to ash, grind the herb, then mix and simmer for two turns.

Game effect: Restore 4d4 + 4 hit points.

Apothecary's observation: *A little ash in the vial is expected.*

Entry X — Potion of Mind Reading

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Clear water

Solutes: Mergrass, Weavemoss

Preparation: Grind both plants, mix, and distill the fragrant vapor into a clean vial over two turns.

Game effect: For 10 minutes, you can use *detect thoughts* (spell save DC 13) without concentration; once used, the potion ends.

Apothecary's observation: *What is overheard cannot always be unheard.*

Entry XI — Potion of Speed

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Hyena Ear, Haste Spores

Preparation: Dry and grind both materials, dissolve in wine, and heat gently for two turns.

Game effect: Gain the effects of *haste* for 3 rounds (no concentration). When it ends, you suffer the spell's normal lethargy until the end of your next turn.

Apothecary's observation: *A dangerous favorite of duelists who expect quick victories.*

Entry XII — Elixir of Fire Resistance

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Sesame oil

Solutes: Dragon Egg Mushroom, Fire Amber

Preparation: Burn the dried mushroom to ash, powder the amber, and mix into warm oil for two turns.

Game effect: Gain resistance to fire damage for 1 hour.

Apothecary's observation: *Shake thoroughly before drinking; the bright grains sink to the bottom.*

Entry XIII — Elixir of Barkskin

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Tree sap

Solutes: Wood Bark, Chasm Creeper

Preparation: Grind the bark, shred the creeper, and dissolve both in warmed sap for two turns.

Game effect: For 1 hour, your AC cannot be lower than 16, as with *barkskin*.

Apothecary's observation: *It leaves the skin textured like polished timber.*

Entry XIV — Night-Watch Elixir

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Crystalline Lens, Nightlight

Preparation: Powder the lens, steep Nightlight, then distill the mixture for two turns.

Game effect: Gain darkvision out to 60 feet for 1 hour; if you already have it, increase its range by 30 feet.

Apothecary's observation: *Especially valued by guards assigned to unlit watchtowers.*

Entry XV — Jade-Marrow Restorative

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Ginseng root, Goji berries

Preparation: Grind the ginseng, crush the berries, and simmer in wine for two turns.

Game effect: Gain 1d6 temporary hit points for 1 hour.

Apothecary's observation: *Among itinerant physicians, this is the medicine offered when rest is impossible.*

Entry XVI — Still-Pond Breathing Tea

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Hot water

Solutes: Lotus root, Bamboo leaf

Preparation: Grind lotus root, add bamboo leaf, and boil for two turns.

Game effect: For 1 hour, you can hold your breath for 15 minutes at a time.

Apothecary's observation: *River divers prize it; it does not allow breathing underwater.*

Entry XVII — Incense of the Steady Hand

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Skilled | **Hourglass:** 2 turns

Solvent: Clear water

Solutes: Sandalwood ash, Chrysanthemum blossoms

Preparation: Burn a prepared pinch of sandalwood to ash, steep blossoms, and mix for two turns.

Game effect: For 1 hour, add 1d4 to one Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check or one check made with a tool; the bonus is then expended.

Apothecary's observation: *Some call it an artisan's tonic; others insist it is a cheat.*

Chapter V: Masterwork Preparations and Rare Virtues

Entry XVIII — Potion of Superior Healing

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Yellow Musk Creeper Petals, Balsam, Rogue's Morsel

Preparation: Grind the petals and herb, burn the Balsam to ash, then boil and filter for three turns.

Game effect: Restore 8d4 + 8 hit points.

Apothecary's observation: *Its amber surface is flecked with soft yellow light.*

Entry XIX — Potion of Supreme Healing

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Distilled water

Solutes: Ki-Rin Hair, Balsam, Yellow Musk Creeper Petals

Preparation: Burn the Balsam, grind the petals, suspend the hair in water, and distill for three turns.

Game effect: Restore 10d4 + 20 hit points.

Apothecary's observation: *The use of a sacred creature's hair makes the provenance of every vial a moral concern.*

Entry XX — Potion of Flying

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Eagle Feather, Wispweed, Autumn Crocus

Preparation: Burn a feather to ash, grind the flowers and weed, then distill for three turns.

Game effect: Gain a flying speed of 60 feet for 10 minutes as with *fly*, without concentration.

Apothecary's observation: *A physician should first ask whether the patient fears heights.*

Entry XXI — Potion of Invisibility

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Clear water

Solutes: Imp Patagium, Mergrass, Shadowroot Sac

Preparation: Grind the membrane and sea grass, dilute a trace of the sac in water, then distill for three turns.

Game effect: Become invisible for 1 hour, or until you attack or cast a spell, as with *invisibility*.

Apothecary's observation: *A dishonest servant is not made honest by becoming unseen.*

Entry XXII — Elixir of Heroism

Provenance: BG3-inspired | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Pegasus Feather, Ginseng root, Wispweed

Preparation: Burn the feather to ash, grind the root and weed, and warm in wine for three turns.

Game effect: For 1 hour, gain 10 temporary hit points and the effects of *bless* on yourself (no concentration).

Apothecary's observation: *Its taste is austere, like rain on old stone.*

Entry XXIII — Golden Bell Tonic

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Tree sap

Solutes: Reishi mushroom, Ginseng root, Jade powder

Preparation: Grind the mushroom and root, suspend jade powder in warmed sap, and stir for three turns.

Game effect: For 10 minutes, gain resistance to bludgeoning damage from nonmagical attacks.

Apothecary's observation: *A guarded recipe of body-cultivators, not an excuse to stand before a charging ox.*

Entry XXIV — Five-Elements Harmony Decoction

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Lotus seed, Dragon Egg Mushroom, Viridian Crystal

Preparation: Grind the seed and crystal, burn the mushroom to ash, then boil for three turns.

Game effect: Choose acid, cold, fire, lightning, or thunder when brewed. The drinker gains resistance to that damage type for 1 hour.

Apothecary's observation: *The practitioner selects one virtue; the draught never grants all five.*

Entry XXV — Moon-Gate Dream Elixir

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Night Orchid, Lotus blossom, Mergrass

Preparation: Grind the lotus, mix with orchid and Mergrass, and distill for three turns under a shaded hood.

Game effect: Within 10 minutes of drinking, the creature may enter a 10-minute trance, gaining advantage on one Wisdom (Insight) check made concerning a remembered conversation.

Apothecary's observation: *It reveals no objective truth; the dreamer must still interpret memory.*

Entry XXVI — Breath of the Mountain Sage

Provenance: Tianxia original | **Grade:** Masterwork | **Hourglass:** 3 turns

Solvent: Pine sap

Solutes: Reishi mushroom, Bamboo leaf, Wispweed

Preparation: Grind the reishi, shred the leaf, and slowly dissolve into warm pine sap over three turns.

Game effect: For 1 hour, gain advantage on Constitution saving throws made to maintain concentration.

Apothecary's observation: *Traditionally carried by traveling calligraphers and Qi practitioners.*

Chapter VI: What May Be Substituted

Certain ingredients are rare in Tianxia, particularly those gathered from extraordinary beasts. The prudent apothecary records the virtue of an ingredient as carefully as its name. A GM may permit substitutions that share an obvious fictional role, but the substituted recipe should retain its original number of solutes and its difficulty.

Rare solute	Possible Tianxia equivalent (GM approval)
Rogue's Morsel	A locally gathered woundwort or medicinal moss
Wispweed	A wind-fed mountain reed, properly cultivated
Ki-Rin Hair	A single hair gifted by a sacred qilin
Pegasus Feather	A feather from a rare celestial steed
Dragon Egg Mushroom	A fungus growing in geothermal or dragon-touched earth
Mergrass	River-silk algae gathered from deep, still pools
Viridian Crystal	Powder from a jade-green mineral vein

These are narrative substitutions, not extra solutes. Salt, sugar, cloth, wax seals, and ordinary bottles are tools and packaging rather than recipe ingredients unless explicitly listed as a solute.

Appendix I: The Apothecary’s Quick Index

One-solute preparations

I. Potion of Healing

II. Antidote

III. Draught of Animal Speech

IV. Feather-Fall Cordial

V. Glorious Vaulting Tonic

VI. Clear-Eye Tea

VII. Ginger-Warmth Draught

VIII. Bitter-Reed Stomach Tonic

Two-solute preparations

IX. Potion of Greater Healing

X. Potion of Mind Reading

XI. Potion of Speed

XII. Elixir of Fire Resistance

XIII. Elixir of Barkskin

XIV. Night-Watch Elixir

XV. Jade-Marrow Restorative

XVI. Still-Pond Breathing Tea

XVII. Incense of the Steady Hand

Three-solute preparations

XVIII. Potion of Superior Healing

XIX. Potion of Supreme Healing

XX. Potion of Flying

XXI. Potion of Invisibility

XXII. Elixir of Heroism

XXIII. Golden Bell Tonic

XXIV. Five-Elements Harmony Decoction

XXV. Moon-Gate Dream Elixir

XXVI. Breath of the Mountain Sage

Appendix II: Cautions and the Judgment of a Physician

The commonest failure in alchemy is not an explosion, but the assumption that a remedy answers a question it was never asked. A potion that mends wounds will not mend a broken promise. A potion that reveals thoughts will not prove their truth. A potion that defeats poison will not forgive the hand that administered it.

If the vessel smells of rancid fat, if sediment has become furred with mold, or if an inexperienced assistant claims that the mixture has begun speaking, do not serve it. Clean the cauldron, ask a second opinion, and begin again.

I have known men to spend more upon a single elixir than their village spends on winter grain. I do not forbid such purchases. I merely suggest that one consider whether the intended miracle might be achieved more cheaply with water, rice, a dry blanket, or kindness.

— Wei Zhen, Scholar-Physician

Editorial Note on Ingredients

This fictional collection borrows raw ingredient names and potion concepts from *Baldur's Gate 3* alchemy while replacing its extract-pair recipes with the Tianxia one-solvent, one-to-three-solute convention. East Asian-inspired additions are original fantasy creations, not historical medicinal formulas. Mechanics use suggested D&D 5e-style effects and can be adjusted by the GM.

Source reference: https://bg3.wiki/wiki/Alchemy (ingredient and potion list); user-provided Fextralife Potion Recipes page (unavailable for direct retrieval during compilation).